

A little eHelp from our judicious friends

Digital access is **inarguably** a component of the fundamental right to life. But **enforcing** it will require a **nuanced** approach over availability and **affordability**. **As things stand now**, Wednesday's Supreme Court **verdict** will **address denial** of the right when it's accessible. Lawmakers will have to **incorporate** digital access into the **statutes** to ensure universal availability. GoI will have to **tweak** policy to make it universally affordable. This has **implications** on the market **dynamics** of, among others, the telecom industry that provides the **backbone** for digital services in the country. A close **analogy** is the electricity industry, which has **morphed** from a regular service to an **essential** one, and **eventually** to a legal **entitlement**. The **transition** has not been smooth in the power sector. Telecom could face some **upheaval** as well.

The **need** to make inexpensive telecom services **ubiquitous** **will** require a revaluation of how India goes about **rolling out** cellular networks. Current policy favours GoI recovering spectrum costs upfront - and sharing revenues as telecom networks expand - which slows growth of the digital economy. A greater **sense** of urgency to grow telecom networks **will** also shape technology preferences among **terrestrial** and satellite communications. Finally, it **reinforces** the role of the state in **addressing** market **imperfections** that **lead to** areas being underserved.



These changes will take time. But the **interpretation** of digital access as a fundamental right **ought to** speed up things. The economy has a deep **digital divide**. But efforts to bridge it should avoid **capital infusion** being **held to ransom** by politics of entitlement, as in the power sector. Fortunately, telecom technology is advancing rapidly, which **brings down** costs and **broadens** markets, **thereby** serving accessibility. The **landmark** ruling helps by focusing on the intent of the legislative and policy **establishment**. The legal interpretation **stretches** both market and state capacity on digital services, and could be **criticised** as judicial **overreach**. But such a conclusion would be **misplaced**.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Judicious** (adjective) – wise, prudent, sensible, thoughtful, astute विवेकपूर्ण
2. **Inarguably** (adverb) – unquestionably, undeniably, certainly, clearly, evidently निर्विवाद रूप से
3. **Enforce** (verb) – implement, impose, uphold, apply, carry out लागू करना
4. **Nuanced** (adjective) – subtle, refined, detailed, layered, delicate सूक्ष्म / जटिल
5. **Affordability** (noun) – cost-effectiveness, reasonableness, economy, budget-friendliness, accessibility वहन करने की क्षमता
6. **As things stand now** (phrase) – currently, at present, as of now, at this point, for the time being वर्तमान स्थिति में
7. **Verdict** (noun) – judgment, decision, ruling, decree, pronouncement निर्णय / फैसला
8. **Address** (verb) – deal with, tackle, handle, respond to, resolve समाधान करना
9. **Denial** (noun) – refusal, rejection, dismissal, withholding, non-acceptance अस्वीकार
10. **Incorporate** (verb) – include, integrate, combine, merge, assimilate सम्मिलित करना
11. **Statute** (noun) – law, legislation, regulation, act, ordinance कानून
12. **Tweak** (verb) – adjust, modify, fine-tune, alter, revise थोड़ा सुधार करना
13. **Implication** (noun) – consequence, result, impact, effect, inference प्रभाव
14. **Dynamic** (noun) – interaction, mechanism, relationship, force, activity प्रणालीगत संबंध
15. **Backbone** (noun) – foundation, core, support, mainstay, infrastructure आधार
16. **Analogy** (noun) – comparison, parallel, similarity, correspondence, likeness समानता
17. **Morph** (verb) – transform, change, convert, evolve, shift रूपांतरित होना
18. **Essential** (adjective) – necessary, vital, critical, indispensable, fundamental आवश्यक
19. **Eventually** (adverb) – finally, ultimately, in the end, at last, after a while अंततः
20. **Entitlement** (noun) – right, claim, privilege, benefit, allocation अधिकार
21. **Transition** (noun) – change, shift, transformation, evolution, conversion परिवर्तन
22. **Upheaval** (noun) – disruption, turmoil, disturbance, chaos, unrest उथल-पुथल

23. **Ubiquitous** (adjective) – widespread, omnipresent, everywhere, universal, pervasive सर्वव्यापी
24. **Roll out** (phrasal verb) – launch, introduce, implement, deploy, commence शुरू करना
25. **Terrestrial** (adjective) – earth-based, land-based, ground-based, non-satellite, physical स्थलीय
26. **Reinforce** (verb) – strengthen, support, bolster, fortify, uphold मज़बूत करना
27. **Address** (verb) – focus on, resolve, confront, attend to, remedy ध्यान देना
28. **Imperfection** (noun) – flaw, defect, shortcoming, deficiency, limitation दोष
29. **Lead** (to) (verb) – result in, cause, bring about, give rise to, contribute to वजह बनना
30. **Ought to** (modal verb) – should, must, need to, have to, expected to करना चाहिए
31. **Digital divide** (noun) – technological gap, access disparity, connectivity inequality, tech inequality, broadband gap तकनीकी असमानता
32. **Capital infusion** (noun) – investment, funding, financial support, monetary input, resource allocation पूंजी निवेश
33. **Hold to ransom** (phrase) – control forcibly, exploit, pressure, coerce, blackmail मजबूर करना
34. **Bring down** (phrasal verb) – reduce, lower, decrease, cut, diminish कम करना
35. **Broaden** (verb) – expand, widen, enlarge, extend, increase विस्तार करना
36. **Thereby** (adverb) – thus, consequently, as a result, hence, accordingly इस प्रकार / परिणामस्वरूप
37. **Landmark** (adjective) – historic, significant, notable, precedent-setting, momentous – ऐतिहासिक
38. **Establishment** (noun) – institution, system, organization, regime, framework स्थापना
39. **Stretch** (verb) – extend, expand, strain, test, broaden फैलाना
40. **Criticise** (verb) – condemn, disapprove, censure, fault, denounce आलोचना करना
41. **Overreach** (noun) – excess, overextension, transgression, overstepping, encroachment सीमा से बाहर जाना
42. **Misplaced** (adjective) – incorrect, inappropriate, mistaken, unfounded, unjustified गलत

Summary of the Editorial

1. The Supreme Court has ruled that digital access is part of the fundamental right to life.
2. However, enforcement of this right requires careful handling of availability and affordability.
3. The verdict primarily addresses denial of digital access where it already exists.
4. Lawmakers must amend statutes to guarantee universal availability of digital access.
5. The Government of India (GoI) needs to adjust policies to make digital access affordable for all.
6. These changes will significantly affect market dynamics, particularly in the telecom sector.
7. The editorial draws a parallel with the electricity sector, which became a legal entitlement over time.
8. Similar to electricity, the telecom sector may face upheaval during the transition to a legal right.
9. Inexpensive telecom services must become ubiquitous, necessitating a policy shift in how networks are deployed.
10. The current telecom policy, which seeks upfront spectrum costs, slows network expansion.
11. A revised strategy may influence the balance between terrestrial and satellite communication technologies.
12. The state will have to play a larger role in correcting market failures that leave some areas underserved.
13. While such structural changes will take time, the legal interpretation adds urgency to reforms.
14. Efforts to bridge the digital divide must avoid the politicisation and inefficiencies seen in the power sector.
15. Despite potential critiques of judicial overreach, the Court's move rightly pushes both market and state toward universal digital access.



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